

**Reframing Climate Change: A Systems Perspective on Power, War, and
Inequality**

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In 2023, satellite images of the war in Sudan revealed something extremely disturbing, dark red stains visible from space, where violence had unfolded on the ground. At the same time, satellite images showing nearby oil infrastructure burning, sending plumes of carbon into the atmosphere. From above, the connection becomes undeniable, human conflict and environmental destruction are intertwined. Climate change is not unfolding separately from these events, it is embedded within the same systems of war, power, and exploitation.

Climate change is often labelled a technical problem of emissions and energy transition. However, this perspective overlooks the deeper systems that drive it. Drawing on systems thinking, climate change must be understood as the outcome of interconnected global structures, particularly war, capitalism, and inequality (IPCC, 2023). These systems are shaped by powerful actors, including states, corporations, and economic elites, who often prioritize profit and geopolitical dominance over sustainability. This perspective directly reflects the systems thinking approach discussed in Week 10, which emphasizes that climate change cannot be understood in isolation, but only through the interconnected political, economic, and social systems that produce it. This reflection essay argues that climate change is not the root crisis, but a symptom of power-driven systems, especially war and profit-oriented economic structures and that meaningful solutions require reframing the issue to expose and challenge these underlying forces.

Now if climate change is driven by systems of power and profit, then technological fixes alone are insufficient. The most effective solution is a systemic and narrative shift that reframes climate change as a political and economic issue, rather than an isolated environmental problem. War plays a central role in this

system. Military institutions are among the largest consumers of fossil fuels, yet their emissions are often excluded from international climate agreements (Crawford, 2019). Beyond emissions, war devastates ecosystems, displaces populations, and reinforces a global order based on competition rather than cooperation. This dynamic reflects broader critiques of global systems where economic growth and geopolitical dominance are prioritized, even when they conflict with environmental sustainability (Xie, 2026). Resources that could be invested in sustainability are instead directed toward conflict, perpetuating environmental harm. In this sense, war does not just contribute to climate change, it sustains the conditions that make it worse.

At the same time, economic systems encourage environmental exploitation. As Klein (2014) argues, crisis situations often allow powerful actors to profit while avoiding accountability. Our global economy depends on continuous growth, requiring extraction and consumption that exceed planetary limits. Even solutions like renewable energy can reproduce harm if they operate within the same profit-driven logic, relying on resource extraction and prioritizing economic returns over long-term sustainability (UNEP, 2021).

A common counterargument is that individual behavior and technological innovation such as reducing personal carbon footprints or scaling renewable energy are sufficient to address climate change. While these efforts are important, they fail to address the structural drivers of emissions. Without systemic change, individual actions remain limited in both scale and impact. Therefore, the most effective solution is to reframe climate change as a systemic issue of power and accountability. This shift places responsibility on institutions rather than individuals

and challenges the legitimacy of systems that prioritize profit over survival.

Implementation requires integrating this perspective into education, media, and policy, while increasing transparency around military emissions, regulating corporate environmental impact, and redirecting resources toward sustainable development (IPCC, 2023).

This reframing has the potential to mobilize a broader audience because it connects climate change to issues of justice, inequality, and human security. Those who contribute least to climate change are often the most affected, facing displacement, poverty, and instability (UNHCR, 2020). By exposing how power and profit shape environmental outcomes, climate change becomes not only an environmental issue but also a moral and political one.

For the reader, the next step is to critically engage with how climate change is framed in everyday discourse. Question narratives that focus solely on individual responsibility while ignoring systemic actors. Support policies and organizations that promote accountability, sustainability, and who are against starting and promoting conflicts around the world. Engaging in conversations, voting, and supporting systemic change can collectively shift public pressure and influence decision making.

Climate change is not an isolated environmental crisis, it is a reflection of systems organized around power and profit. Addressing it requires confronting these structures directly. Without this shift, solutions will remain superficial. With it, there is potential not only to address climate change, but to transform the systems that created it.

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